

STAGE NINE • ENGLISH VOCABULARY FIRST SET

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 38 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Nine • English Vocabulary First Set

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Stage Nine is structurally different from most other stages: its thirty-eight FIRSTS are vocabulary sets, not reflection or action exercises. This changes what a facilitator actually needs to do — less about prompting personal disclosure, more about drilling active use and catching the specific errors that come from treating vocabulary as passive recognition rather than genuine, usable fluency.

Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective (framed around active, correct use in an original sentence, not just recognizing a definition), Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt, organized into this stage's six existing sections: Core Vocabulary Building Blocks, Written & Documentation Vocabulary, Meeting & Verbal Communication Vocabulary, Presentation & Persuasion Vocabulary, Self-Presentation & Networking Vocabulary, and Problem-Solving & Growth Vocabulary.

A recurring theme across this entire stage: passive recognition of a word is not the same as genuine fluency. Nearly every misconception list below includes some version of “learning the definition without ever using it in a real, original sentence.” Build active production, out loud or in writing, into every session rather than treating this as a reading assignment.

SESSION 1

Core Vocabulary Building Blocks

Covers *FIRSTS M1-M10*

FIRST M1

20 Professional Adjectives Learned

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants use at least three of the twenty adjectives correctly and naturally in a real sentence about their own experience.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These words appear constantly in resumes, LinkedIn profiles, and reviews — fluency here replaces the same two or three overused words with precise, varied language.
- Study five words at a time, not all twenty at once; depth beats breadth in a single sitting.
- The real test is active use in an original sentence, not passive recognition of a definition.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Memorizing definitions without ever writing a real, original sentence, which leaves the vocabulary passive.
 - Defaulting back to “hardworking” and “team player” out of habit instead of reaching for the new, more precise words.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M2

20 Action Verbs Learned for CVs/Resumes

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite one resume bullet using a strong action verb in place of a passive phrase like “was responsible for.”

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A strong opening verb communicates ownership and impact far more than a passive construction.
- The verb needs to be genuinely accurate to what happened, not just the most impressive-sounding option available.
- This directly feeds Stage Two's resume work — flag that connection explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing an impressive verb that overstates what was actually done, which can read as exaggeration in an interview.
- Reusing the same one or two verbs across every bullet point instead of drawing from the full list.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M3

10 Transition Words for Writing

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify the correct logical relationship (cause, contrast, addition, sequence) for a transition word before using it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Transition words signal logical relationships between ideas — their absence makes writing feel choppy even when content is strong.
- Each transition word implies a specific logical relationship; using the wrong one actively confuses a reader rather than just sounding slightly off.
- A quick classification drill (cause vs. contrast vs. addition) before free writing prevents the most common errors.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using “therefore” when the actual relationship is contrast, not consequence — a very common, easily corrected error.
 - Treating all transition words as interchangeable synonyms for “and.”
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M4

10 Academic Phrases for Reports/Emails

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants use two structural phrases correctly to signpost an argument in a short paragraph.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These phrases show a reader exactly where they are in an argument, making formal writing far easier to navigate.
- The goal is natural structure, not stiffness — overuse is a genuine, common risk with this list specifically.
- Practice with a real report or email draft, not a hypothetical example.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Overusing these phrases until writing sounds stiff and overly formal rather than naturally structured.
 - Inserting a structural phrase without the paragraph actually following through on the structure it promises.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M5

20 Workplace Phrases for Communication

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify which of several sample phrases feels genuinely natural versus template-like, and explain why.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These phrases are the everyday connective tissue of workplace communication — fluency here signals natural professionalism.
- The line between “professionally fluent” and “robotic template” is genuinely thin with this list; discuss it explicitly.
- Encourage participants to notice which phrases they already use unconsciously versus which are genuinely new.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using these phrases so rigidly that every message sounds like the same template.
- Assuming more formal phrasing is always safer, even in genuinely casual internal contexts.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M6

10 Vocabulary Words for Presentations

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants replace one instance of vague filler (“so yeah, this is important”) with precise structural language.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This vocabulary gives precise language for guiding an audience through structure, replacing vague verbal filler.
- Filler is often an unconscious habit — recording a short practice segment can make it genuinely audible to the speaker for the first time.
- This connects directly to the Presentation & Persuasion section (M26–M31) later in this stage.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying on vague filler phrases out of habit rather than the more precise structural vocabulary available.
- Assuming filler is only a minor issue rather than something that genuinely undercuts perceived competence.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M7

10 Words for Networking Conversations

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants use two networking words naturally in a mock introduction without sounding scripted.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This vocabulary frames networking conversations around genuine professional value rather than purely transactional small talk.
- Natural delivery matters as much as correct usage — practice out loud, not just on paper.
- This connects directly to Section 5 (Self-Presentation & Networking) later in this stage.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using these words so frequently or artificially that the conversation feels scripted rather than genuine.
- Treating networking vocabulary as a performance rather than language supporting a genuine conversation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M8

10 Polite Expressions for Professional Settings

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants select an appropriately calibrated polite expression for three different sample scenarios varying in formality.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A genuine repertoire beyond one overused phrase makes communication feel more authentic, not more distant.
- Calibration matters: the right level of politeness varies by context, relationship, and stakes.
- Excess politeness is a real, common failure mode with this list — name it explicitly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Stacking multiple polite expressions in one message until it feels excessive or insincere.
- Using the same maximally formal expression regardless of the actual context or relationship.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M9

10 Common Academic/Business Idioms

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants correctly explain the meaning of five idioms and identify one context where using it might cause cross-cultural confusion.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These idioms appear constantly in workplace conversation — recognizing them supports comprehension even before active use.
- Judicious use matters here more than almost any other list in this stage; idioms can genuinely confuse international or cross-cultural audiences.
- Comprehension (being able to follow a conversation using these idioms) is itself a valid, sufficient goal, separate from active production.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using idioms heavily in cross-cultural or international settings where they may not translate clearly.
 - Assuming an idiom's literal words explain its actual, non-literal meaning.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST M10

10 Vocabulary Reflection Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write five genuinely personal sentences (not generic textbook examples) using words from earlier in this section.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Vocabulary read passively rarely becomes genuinely usable; actively constructing your own sentences converts recognition into real fluency.
- This closes Section 1 by testing retention across the whole section, not just the most recent list.
- Push participants toward specificity: a sentence about their own actual field or experience, not a generic textbook example.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing generic, textbook-style example sentences instead of ones genuinely connected to your own field or life.
 - Choosing only the easiest, most familiar words rather than genuinely testing retention across the section.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 2

Written & Documentation Vocabulary

Covers *FIRSTS M11-M15*

FIRST M11

Professional Email Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite one real email to be clear, concise, and appropriately polite without burying the actual point.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Email is the most common written professional channel — clear, concise, polite vocabulary directly affects response speed and favorability.
- Politeness and clarity can genuinely trade off against each other; the goal is enough of each, not maximum of either.
- Use a real, recent email as the practice material, not a hypothetical one.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Prioritizing politeness so heavily the email becomes long and unclear, burying the actual point.
 - Assuming more words signal more professionalism, rather than clarity doing that work.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M12

Report & Memo Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants label a short sample report's sections using correct standard terminology, matching label to actual content.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These structural terms are the standard scaffolding of formal business writing — using them correctly signals genuine familiarity with the convention.
- The label must actually match what's underneath it; a mismatch is a common, easily-caught error.
- This connects to Stage Fourteen's project status reports and Stage Fifteen's business case work later in the program.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using structural terms as headers without actually structuring the content underneath to match.
 - Assuming any formal-sounding label is interchangeable with the standard, expected term.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M13

Agenda/Minutes Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants distinguish a decision, an action item, and an open discussion point in a sample meeting summary using precise vocabulary for each.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Accurate meeting documentation depends on precise vocabulary that clearly distinguishes decisions from discussion and assigns real ownership.
- “We talked about” is vague in a way that causes genuine downstream confusion — precise alternatives exist for a reason.
- This directly supports the meeting documentation skills built in Stage Six and Stage Fourteen.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using vague language (“we talked about”) instead of precise terms that distinguish decisions, actions, and discussion.
- Recording an action item without a named owner, which the correct vocabulary should make visibly incomplete.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M14

Vocabulary for Documenting Decisions and Next Steps

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write one decision statement that's unambiguous about whether it's final or still tentative.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Clear decision-documentation language prevents later confusion about what was actually agreed — a common, real source of team friction.
- Ambiguity about finality (“we're leaning toward” vs. “we've decided”) is the single most common failure point with this vocabulary.
- This is genuinely high-leverage vocabulary; a small wording difference has real downstream consequences.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Documenting a decision so vaguely that it's unclear whether it's final or still tentative.
- Using “decided” language for something that was actually just discussed or proposed.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M15

Vocabulary for Summarizing Findings from Research or Projects

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants revise one overstated claim (“this proves”) into an appropriately calibrated one (“this suggests”) matching the actual strength of the evidence.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Precise summarizing language helps a reader quickly grasp actual findings without wading through unnecessary detail.
- Calibrating certainty (proves vs. suggests vs. indicates) matters as much as clarity — overstating undermines credibility once someone checks the underlying data.
- This closes Section 2, and connects directly to the data-driven decision-making work in later stages.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Overstating certainty with phrases like “this proves” when the data only supports a more modest claim.
- Underselling a genuinely strong finding out of excessive caution, which can bury real, actionable insight.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 3

Meeting & Verbal Communication Vocabulary

Covers *FIRSTS M16, M17, M22, M18, M23–M25, M38*

FIRST M16

Meeting/Call Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice using one natural entry phrase to join an ongoing conversation without interrupting awkwardly.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- These phrases help you enter and exit points in a live conversation naturally, rather than interrupting or staying silent.
- Waiting for perfect silence rarely works in a real meeting — a natural entry phrase is the actual skill.
- Practice out loud in pairs; this vocabulary doesn't transfer from silent reading the way written vocabulary does.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Waiting for a perfect silence to speak instead of using a natural entry phrase to join an ongoing conversation.
- Treating interruption phrases as inherently rude rather than a normal, expected part of live conversation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M17

Negotiation & Persuasion Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants advocate for a position in a short mock exchange without sounding either weak or adversarial.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Persuasive, collaborative language helps you advocate for your position without sounding weak or adversarial.
- The line between persuasion and manipulation is genuinely about intent, not vocabulary — discuss that distinction explicitly.
- This connects directly to Stage Fifteen's negotiation and business case work later in the program.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using persuasive language to manipulate rather than genuinely find a fair, mutual outcome.
- Avoiding assertive language entirely out of fear of sounding adversarial, which undercuts genuine advocacy.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M22

Follow-Up Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft one follow-up message that's appropriately brief and direct, without over-apologizing for a reasonable ask.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Follow-up is where many professional relationships and processes quietly stall; natural language makes the habit easier to sustain.
- Over-apologizing is the dominant failure mode here — a routine, reasonable follow-up doesn't need extensive justification.
- This directly supports the ongoing communication habits built throughout Stage Six and Stage Ten.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-apologizing in follow-up language, which can make a routine, reasonable follow-up sound like an imposition.
- Avoiding follow-up altogether out of concern about seeming pushy.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M18

Feedback Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver one piece of feedback using precise language that stays clear without becoming harsh.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Precise feedback language helps you deliver criticism kindly and receive it gracefully — both depend heavily on word choice, not just tone.
- Softening language can go too far and obscure the actual point being made; that's a genuine, common risk.
- This connects directly to the feedback skills built in Stage Eight and Stage Twelve.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using softening language so heavily that the actual feedback becomes unclear or gets lost entirely.
- Confusing bluntness with clarity, when precise, calibrated language achieves clarity without unnecessary harshness.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M23

Follow-Up Vocabulary After Networking

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft one post-networking follow-up that includes a specific detail from the actual conversation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The specific language used in a follow-up affects whether a contact perceives it as genuine relationship-building or a generic, forgettable message.
- A real, specific detail from the actual conversation is what separates this from a template — emphasize that explicitly.
- This directly extends M22's general follow-up vocabulary into a specifically networking context.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using this vocabulary without any specific detail from the actual conversation, which reads as a generic template.
- Waiting too long after the conversation to follow up, which undermines even well-crafted language.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M24

Question-Asking Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite one closed yes/no question into a genuinely open-ended one.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Open-ended questions produce far richer conversations and more useful information than closed yes/no questions.
- A question can sound open-ended in structure while still being easily answered with one word — that's the trap to watch for.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Question-Asking Skill (B24) and the interview skills built in Stage Three.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking a question that sounds open-ended but is actually easily answered with a single word, missing the intended depth.
- Stacking multiple questions at once, which makes it unclear which one the other person should actually answer.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M25

Listening & Responding Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants use one genuine paraphrase (not a mechanical stock phrase) to confirm understanding in a real exchange.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This vocabulary makes active listening visible to the other person, confirming genuine understanding rather than passive silence.
- The phrase only works if it's followed by an actually accurate paraphrase — the words alone don't do the work.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Professional Listening Skill (B25) built earlier in the program.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using these phrases mechanically without genuinely following up with an accurate paraphrase.
- Treating a listening phrase as a filler pause rather than as a genuine confirmation of understanding.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M38

Vocabulary for Giving and Receiving Constructive Feedback

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants apply advanced feedback vocabulary to a higher-stakes, more sensitive sample scenario than M18 covered.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- This advanced vocabulary handles higher-stakes or more sensitive feedback situations, where basic phrasing alone isn't enough.
- This closes the section by extending M18's foundational feedback vocabulary into genuinely difficult territory.
- Discuss a real (anonymized) example of a higher-stakes feedback conversation if participants have one to draw from.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Defaulting to basic feedback phrases that don't carry enough weight for a genuinely significant conversation.
- Assuming higher-stakes feedback requires harsher language, rather than more careful, precise language.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 4

Presentation & Persuasion Vocabulary

Covers *FIRSTS* M26–M31

FIRST M26

Presentation Introduction Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver one confident, unscripted-sounding presentation opener using this vocabulary.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A confident, clear opening sets the tone for the entire presentation — vague or hesitant language can undercut audience confidence before content even starts.
- Nerves are highest at the very start, which is exactly when leaving the opening improvised is riskiest.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Professional Introduction (B1) and Elevator Pitch (B2).

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving your opening unscripted and improvised, which is exactly when nerves are highest and vague filler is most likely.
- Opening with an apology or hedge (“sorry, I’m a bit nervous”) instead of confident, prepared language.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M27

Vocabulary for Structuring Presentations

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants add explicit verbal signposting to a short presentation segment, not relying on slide transitions alone.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Explicit structural language helps an audience track where they are, especially in longer or more complex talks.
- Slide transitions alone aren't enough signposting — verbal structure needs to match visual structure.
- This connects directly to Stage Six's presentation vocabulary and Stage Two's Meeting Presence (B23).

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming slide transitions alone signal structure clearly enough, without matching verbal signposting.
- Over-structuring a short, simple presentation until the scaffolding overwhelms the actual content.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M28

Vocabulary for Emphasizing Key Points

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify and verbally emphasize the single most important point in a short sample presentation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without explicit emphasis language, an audience may not know which points matter most, especially in a longer presentation.
- Emphasizing everything is equivalent to emphasizing nothing — this is the core lesson to land here.
- Push participants to genuinely choose just one or two points to emphasize, not scatter emphasis throughout.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Emphasizing too many points, which dilutes the impact of emphasis language and leaves the audience unsure what's most important.
 - Using emphasis language without actually slowing down or pausing to let it land.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M29

Audience Engagement Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants pose one genuine engagement question and practice actually pausing for and incorporating a response.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Engagement language turns a one-way presentation into an interactive exchange, typically increasing attention and retention.
- The pause after the question is as important as the question itself — a question asked and immediately answered by the speaker isn't genuine engagement.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Meeting Presence (B23) and Question-Asking Skill (B24).

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking an engagement question but not genuinely pausing for or incorporating the response, which reads as performative.
 - Asking a question too complex to answer quickly in the format available, stalling the presentation's momentum.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M30

Q&A Handling Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice gracefully acknowledging a question they don't have a complete answer for, rather than bluffing.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Precise Q&A language helps you handle unexpected questions gracefully, including ones without a complete answer, without losing composure.
- Bluffing an answer is a common, high-risk instinct under pressure; graceful acknowledgment plus a genuine follow-up commitment is the better alternative.
- Role-play a genuinely difficult, unexpected question live if the group is comfortable with it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to bluff an answer you don't actually have, rather than gracefully acknowledging the gap and following up later.
- Treating “I don't know” alone as sufficient, without the follow-up commitment that makes it professionally credible.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST M31

Persuasive Speaking Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants close a short persuasive pitch with an explicit, specific ask rather than trailing off.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Persuasive language moves an audience from understanding your point to actually acting on it — a distinct final step beyond mere comprehension.
- Building a strong case throughout a presentation means little if the actual ask at the end is missing or vague.
- This closes the section; connects directly to Stage Two's Elevator Pitch (B2), which has the same “natural close” requirement.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Building a strong persuasive case throughout but failing to close with an explicit ask, leaving the audience unsure what to do next.
- Softening the final ask so much it no longer reads as a genuine request for action.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

SESSION 5

Self-Presentation & Networking Vocabulary

Covers *FIRSTS* M19–M21, M32

FIRST M19

Professional Greeting Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants select an appropriately calibrated greeting for three different sample contexts varying in formality and relationship stage.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A greeting sets the tone for the entire interaction that follows — calibrated language avoids both awkward stiffness and excessive casualness.
- The right greeting depends genuinely on context and relationship stage, not a single universal default.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Professional Introduction (B1), opening the same kind of first-impression window.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using an overly generic greeting that doesn't reflect the actual context or relationship stage.
 - Defaulting to maximum formality even in genuinely casual, already-established relationships.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M20

Self-Introduction Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver a self-introduction removing all hedging language (“I guess,” “sort of,” “maybe”).

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Confident, clear self-introduction language directly shapes a listener's first impression; hedging undercuts even strong content.
- Hedging is often an unconscious habit — have participants listen for it specifically in a partner's practice round.
- This directly extends Stage Two's Professional Introduction (B1) with a specific vocabulary-level lens.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using hedging language (“I guess,” “sort of,” “maybe”) that undercuts otherwise strong content.
- Overcorrecting into language that sounds arrogant rather than simply confident.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M21

Small Talk Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice a 60-second small talk exchange using this vocabulary without rushing through it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Small talk is often the entry point to deeper professional conversation — natural language reduces the awkwardness of opening moments.
- Treating small talk as something to rush through is a common, counterproductive instinct — name that explicitly.
- This connects directly to Stage Two's Professional Conversation Starter (B34).

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating small talk as a chore to rush through, rather than a genuine, low-pressure way to build initial rapport.
- Steering small talk immediately into business topics, undercutting its actual rapport-building function.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M32

Workplace Expression Vocabulary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants select an appropriately calibrated expression for a routine, low-stakes workplace communication.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Everyday workplace expressions help you communicate routine information without sounding overly formal or too casual.
- This closes the section; the calibration skill here mirrors M8's polite expressions but for general workplace communication broadly.
- Routine, low-stakes messages are exactly where over-formality or bluntness stands out most, since the stakes don't justify either extreme.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Defaulting to overly formal or overly blunt language for routine, low-stakes communications that call for a lighter touch.
- Assuming every workplace message needs the same level of formality regardless of actual stakes.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

SESSION 6

Problem-Solving & Growth Vocabulary

Covers *FIRSTS* M33–M37

FIRST M33

Vocabulary for Articulating Challenges and Obstacles

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rewrite one vague complaint (“this isn't working”) into a specific, actionable challenge statement.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Clearly articulated challenges are the necessary first step toward solving them; vague complaints don't give a team enough to act on.
- The test is specificity: could a listener actually identify something concrete to help with after hearing it?
- This connects directly to the Business Problem Analysis work in Stage Fifteen.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Naming a challenge so vaguely that a listener can't identify anything specific to help with.
 - Describing a challenge only in terms of frustration rather than its concrete, actionable substance.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M34

Vocabulary for Proposing Solutions and Alternatives

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants present two genuine alternative solutions, not just one option framed as the only possibility.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Solution-proposing language moves a conversation from problem identification to actual forward progress.
- Presenting only one option, even a good one, can feel like you're not genuinely open to other approaches — real alternatives matter.
- This directly extends M33, moving from naming a problem to proposing genuine forward motion.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Presenting only one option as though it's the only possibility, which can feel closed to genuine input.
- Proposing alternatives so similar to each other that they don't represent a genuine choice.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M35

Vocabulary for Analyzing Pros and Cons

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants name at least one genuine con for their own preferred option in a sample trade-off analysis.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Clear trade-off language helps a team make a genuinely informed decision, rather than defaulting to whichever option was mentioned first.
- Naming a real con for your own preferred option is the genuine test of balanced analysis, not just going through the motions.
- This connects directly to Stage Fifteen's Cost-Benefit Analysis.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only naming the pros of your preferred option, quietly avoiding a genuine, balanced trade-off analysis.
- Listing cons that are trivial or easily dismissed rather than genuinely weighty trade-offs.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M36

Vocabulary for Brainstorming and Ideation Sessions

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice generative language for two minutes without slipping into evaluative language ("that won't work because").

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Idea-building language, as opposed to idea-evaluating language, keeps a brainstorming session generative rather than prematurely critical.
- Slipping into evaluation is a near-universal, unconscious habit — catching it live is the actual skill being built.
- This connects directly to Stage Eight's Collaborative Brainstorm and Stage Thirteen's Collaborative Brainstorming Session.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Slipping into evaluative language ("that won't work because") during the generative phase, which shuts down idea flow prematurely.
- Treating a lack of criticism as a lack of rigor, rather than a deliberate, temporary phase of the process.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST M37

Vocabulary for Reflecting on Personal Growth and Lessons Learned

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants pair one genuine growth statement with a specific, concrete example, not just an abstract claim.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Precise reflective language helps you articulate genuine growth clearly, both to yourself and to others, such as in an interview.
- A growth claim without a specific example is unconvincing; the example is what actually carries the claim's weight.
- This closes out the entire stage, appropriately reflective given everything built across the previous thirty-six FIRSTS.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using growth language without pairing it with a specific, concrete example, which leaves the claim unconvincing.
- Choosing a generic, safe growth story rather than one that's genuinely specific to their own real experience.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*